centred around ‘Jambudwipa’ or the Continent of the Rose Apple that was really not meant as a cartographic description.[2]

I am not suggesting that ancient Indians did not have a sense of geography. If anything, they were very strongly conscious of the layout of the subcontinent and, given their maritime activities, of the Indian Ocean rim. Thus, when the famous eighth-century philosopher Adi Shankaracharya set up four monasteries, he chose sites in the four corners of the country—Puri in the east, Dwarka in the west, Sringeri in the south and Joshimath in the north. This is clearly not a random distribution. Nonetheless, it does seem that cartography as a science did not flourish in ancient India.

In contrast, the Arabs wrote several books on geography during the medieval period. They also preserved some of the works of classical scholars like Ptolemy of Alexandria at a time when Christian Europe would have dismissed such knowledge as pagan. In the twelfth century, the famous Moorish geographer, Al Idrisi, drew a map that combined his own knowledge with that of Ptolemy. It showed the Indian Ocean as landlocked, an idea that suited Arab interests by discouraging any attempt by Europeans to find a sea route to the east. By the fourteenth century, the Persians were drawing maps that show the Indian peninsula. Nonetheless, the quality of cartography remained quite basic. The real experts of medieval cartography were the Chinese. They had long been drawing maps of their own country. By the time of Admiral Zheng He, or perhaps as a result of his voyages, they had good strip-maps of shipping routes through South East Asia and even of parts of the East African coast. These are mostly in the nature of sailing instructions rather than accurate representations of the physical geography, but they are surprisingly detailed and far in advance of anything possessed by other people.

Meanwhile, Europe was literally in the dark about the geography of Asia. The Arabs appear to have been able to enforce an information blockade over centuries. With the works of classical geographers lost and memories of pre-Islamic trade with India fading, Europe was hostage to garbled information and even blatant charlatans. One of the most famous of the